

LOAN DEFAULT RISK ANALYSIS & PORTFOLIO INSIGHTS

A
Comprehensive
Data-Driven
Approach to
Identifying Risk
Segments,
Improving Credit
Decisions, and
Enhancing Loan
Performance

1. Business Background

Effective credit risk and loan portfolio management are critical for optimizing profitability and ensuring long-term stability in the financial services sector. Lending institutions face continuous exposure to financial loss through borrower defaults, mispriced loan products, and inefficient applicant evaluation frameworks. To maintain a healthy, profitable credit portfolio, institutions must continuously refine their approval criteria and risk matrices based on historical repayment behaviors, macroeconomic indicators, and borrower demographics.

2. Stating the Business Problem

The institution currently faces an overall loan default rate of 11.61%, representing significant principal at risk. The primary challenge is to accurately identify the high-risk borrower segments driving these defaults. Relying on outdated or one-dimensional approval criteria creates several critical business challenges:

- **Capital Erosion:** Issuing loans to unidentified high-risk cohorts directly impacts bottom-line profitability through an accumulation of non-performing assets.
 - **Evaluation Blind Spots:** Traditional metrics like raw credit scores are failing to capture the full risk profile of borrowers, particularly when isolated from current income bandwidths.
 - **Opportunity Cost:** Without a multidimensional, data-driven understanding of interacting risk factors (income, DTI, employment type), the institution risks implementing blanket restrictions, thereby losing profitable market share to competitors.
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3. Executive Summary

An exhaustive analysis of 255,347 historical loan records—representing an average loan size of approximately \$144.52K—reveals that traditional credit scoring models are insufficient when evaluated in isolation. A borrower's true capacity to repay is determined by a multidimensional confluence of income bandwidth, employment stability, debt-to-income (DTI) leverage, and co-signer backing.

Key executive insights shaping the proposed credit policy adjustments include:

- **Current Portfolio Exposure:** The institution faces a baseline overall default rate of 11.61%, representing over 30,000 defaulted accounts. This highlights a critical need to refine approval matrices to protect principal investments.
- **Income Bandwidth Outweighs Credit History:** Low-income borrowers (earning <\$20,000) present a severe structural risk that actively supersedes the predictive power of prime credit scores. Borrowers in this lowest income bracket exhibit default rates consistently exceeding 20%, even when holding "Good," "Very Good," or "Excellent" credit ratings.
- **The Co-Signer Risk Buffer:** The absence of a co-signer acts as a universal risk multiplier. Unbacked applicants default at an average rate of 12.87%, whereas securing a co-signer significantly insulates the loan, dropping the default rate to 10.36%.
- **Employment & Cash Flow Vulnerability:** Predictable cash flow is directly correlated with loan performance. Full-time employees present the lowest baseline risk with a default rate of approximately 9.46%. Conversely, unemployed and part-time applicants consistently underperform, driving the highest default volumes specifically within the Business and Education loan categories.
- **Leverage Escalation via DTI:** There is a linear, compounding relationship between high Debt-to-Income ratios and loan delinquency. Borrowers residing in the highest 20% DTI quintile default at rates exceeding 12%, compared to roughly 10.5% for those in the lowest, least-leveraged quintile.
- **Compounding Financial Burdens:** Pre-existing financial obligations, such as active mortgages or a high number of dependents, incrementally strain borrower liquidity and elevate the probability of default when stacked with new loan products.

By pivoting toward a dynamic risk assessment framework—implementing conditional co-signer requirements, adjusting approval matrices for high-risk employment profiles, and enforcing stricter DTI caps—the institution can significantly reduce non-performing assets, intelligently price its risk, and optimize its overall loan product offerings.

4. Key Metrics

- **North Star Metric: Overall Loan Default Rate (Current Baseline: 11.61% — Target: Minimize below baseline).**
 - ***Rationale for Selection:*** This metric serves as the ultimate barometer of credit portfolio health. Minimizing this aggregate rate directly correlates with reduced financial loss, optimized capital allocation, and improved institutional profitability.
 - **Key Predictive Drivers: Debt-to-Income (DTI) Ratio, Employment Type, Income Band, and Loan Purpose.**
 - ***Rationale for Selection:*** A single metric cannot definitively determine whether a borrower will default. Relying on an isolated data point provides an incomplete and often misleading financial picture. By combining DTI (current financial leverage), Employment Type (predictability of cash flow), Income Band (absolute repayment capacity), and Loan Purpose (capital utility), this framework builds a multidimensional risk profile that captures the borrower's true capacity to repay.
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5. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) Methodology

To ensure absolute data integrity and establish a rigorous foundation for predictive insights, the Exploratory Data Analysis was executed in a structured, multi-phase approach prior to any hypothesis testing.

Step 1: Data Ingestion & Initial Inspection

The analysis commenced with the ingestion of a large-scale historical loan dataset comprising 255,347 individual applications. The dataset contains 19 distinct features, offering a robust mix of continuous financial metrics (e.g., Income, Loan Amount, Interest Rate, DTI Ratio) and categorical borrower attributes (e.g., Employment Type, Loan Purpose, Marital Status, Education).

LoanID	Age	Income	LoanAmount	CreditScore	MonthsEmployed	NumCreditLines	InterestRate	LoanTerm	DTIRatio	Education	EmploymentType	MaritalStatus
I38PQUQS96	56	85994	50587	520	80	4	15.23	36	0.44	Bachelor's	Full-time	Divorced
HPSK72WA7R	69	50432	124440	458	15	1	4.81	60	0.68	Master's	Full-time	Married
C1OZ6DPJ8Y	46	84208	129188	451	26	3	21.17	24	0.31	Master's	Unemployed	Divorced
V2KKSFM3UN	32	31713	44799	743	0	3	7.07	24	0.23	High School	Full-time	Married
EY08JDHTZP	60	20437	9139	633	8	4	6.51	48	0.73	Bachelor's	Unemployed	Divorced

MaritalStatus	HasMortgage	HasDependents	LoanPurpose	HasCoSigner	Default	Loan Date (DD/MM/YYYY)
Divorced	Yes	Yes	Other	Yes	0	10/15/2018
Married	No	No	Other	Yes	0	3/25/2016
Divorced	Yes	Yes	Auto	No	1	11/11/2013
Married	No	No	Business	No	0	6/22/2017
Divorced	No	Yes	Auto	No	0	6/9/2014

Step 2: Data Quality Assessment & Structural Validation

A comprehensive data quality audit was performed to identify missing values, structural errors, or duplicate records.

- Null Value Check: The dataset was evaluated using `.isnull().sum()`, confirming exactly zero missing values across all 255,347 records.
- Duplicate Verification: The dataset was tested for duplicate rows using `.duplicated().sum()`, confirming zero duplicated entries.

- **Outcome:** Because the dataset was natively pristine and fully populated, no synthetic data imputation or row-deletion methods were required, ensuring the subsequent analysis reflects 100% of the recorded historical variance.

```
<class 'pandas.core.frame.DataFrame'>
RangeIndex: 255347 entries, 0 to 255346
Data columns (total 19 columns):
#   Column                                Non-Null Count  Dtype
---  -
0   LoanID                               255347 non-null object
1   Age                                   255347 non-null int64
2   Income                               255347 non-null int64
3   LoanAmount                           255347 non-null int64
4   CreditScore                           255347 non-null int64
5   MonthsEmployed                       255347 non-null int64
6   NumCreditLines                       255347 non-null int64
7   InterestRate                         255347 non-null float64
8   LoanTerm                             255347 non-null int64
9   DTIRatio                             255347 non-null float64
10  Education                             255347 non-null object
11  EmploymentType                       255347 non-null object
12  MaritalStatus                        255347 non-null object
13  HasMortgage                          255347 non-null object
14  HasDependents                        255347 non-null object
15  LoanPurpose                           255347 non-null object
16  HasCoSigner                          255347 non-null object
17  Default                               255347 non-null int64
18  Loan Date (DD/MM/YYYY)               255347 non-null object
dtypes: float64(2), int64(8), object(9)
memory usage: 37.0+ MB
```

```
df.isnull().sum()
df.duplicated().sum()
# Count of null values and duplicates are zero. Data is quite cleaned and well structured.
```

```
0
```

Step 3: Statistical Profiling & Baseline Distribution

A 5-number summary (Min, Q1, Median, Q3, Max) alongside mean and standard deviation calculations was generated for all numerical columns to understand the baseline distribution of the portfolio.

- **Borrower Age:** Ranges from 18 to 69, with a median age of 43.
- **Financial Baselines:** The average borrower income sits at \$82,499.30, while the average requested loan amount is \$127,578.86.
- **Credit Health:** The median credit score is 574, and the average Debt-to-Income (DTI) ratio is exactly 0.50.
- **Target Variable:** The baseline overall default rate across the entire dataset is confirmed at 11.61%.

	Age	Income	LoanAmount	CreditScore	MonthsEmployed	NumCreditLines	InterestRate	LoanTerm	DTIRatio	Default
count	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000	255347.000000
mean	43.498306	82499.304597	127578.865512	574.264346	59.541976	2.501036	13.492773	36.025894	0.500212	0.116128
std	14.990258	38963.013729	70840.706142	158.903867	34.643376	1.117018	6.636443	16.969330	0.230917	0.320379
min	18.000000	15000.000000	5000.000000	300.000000	0.000000	1.000000	2.000000	12.000000	0.100000	0.000000
25%	31.000000	48825.500000	66156.000000	437.000000	30.000000	2.000000	7.770000	24.000000	0.300000	0.000000
50%	43.000000	82466.000000	127556.000000	574.000000	60.000000	2.000000	13.460000	36.000000	0.500000	0.000000
75%	56.000000	116219.000000	188985.000000	712.000000	90.000000	3.000000	19.250000	48.000000	0.700000	0.000000
max	69.000000	149999.000000	249999.000000	849.000000	119.000000	4.000000	25.000000	60.000000	0.900000	1.000000

Step 4: Feature Engineering & Dimensionality Grouping

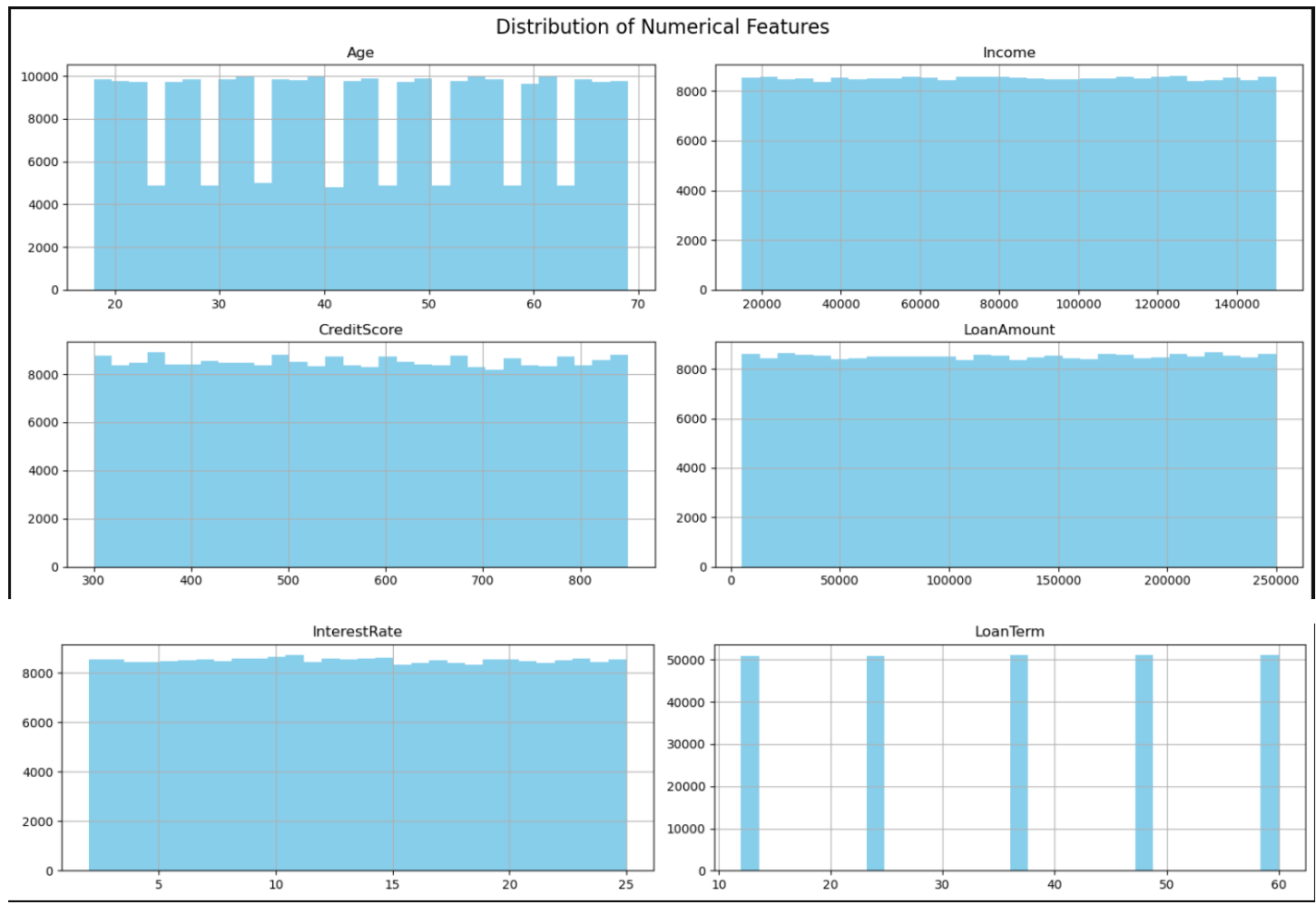
To translate continuous numerical variables into actionable business segments for the upcoming hypothesis testing, targeted feature engineering was applied. Continuous variables were converted into ordered categorical bins to isolate specific risk thresholds:

- **Income Bands:** Engineered into four distinct segments to evaluate purchasing power risk: "Low" (<\$20,000), "Medium" (\$20,000–\$49,999), "High" (\$50,000–\$99,999), and "Very High" (\$100,000+).
- **Credit Score Bands:** Segmented based on standard industry thresholds: "Very Poor" (<580), "Fair" (580–669), "Good" (670–739), "Very Good" (740–799), and "Excellent" (800+).
- **DTI Quintiles:** The continuous DTI Ratio column was binned into five equal percentiles (Lowest 20% through Highest 20%) to track linear risk escalation associated with borrower leverage.

Step 5: Univariate Visualization

Before testing complex interactions, standard univariate distributions were plotted to observe the standalone volume of categorical features. This step ensured there was sufficient sample size

within each category (e.g., verifying adequate volumes across Auto, Business, Education, and Home loans) to ensure statistical validity during the hypothesis testing phase.



6. Hypothesis Testing & Validation

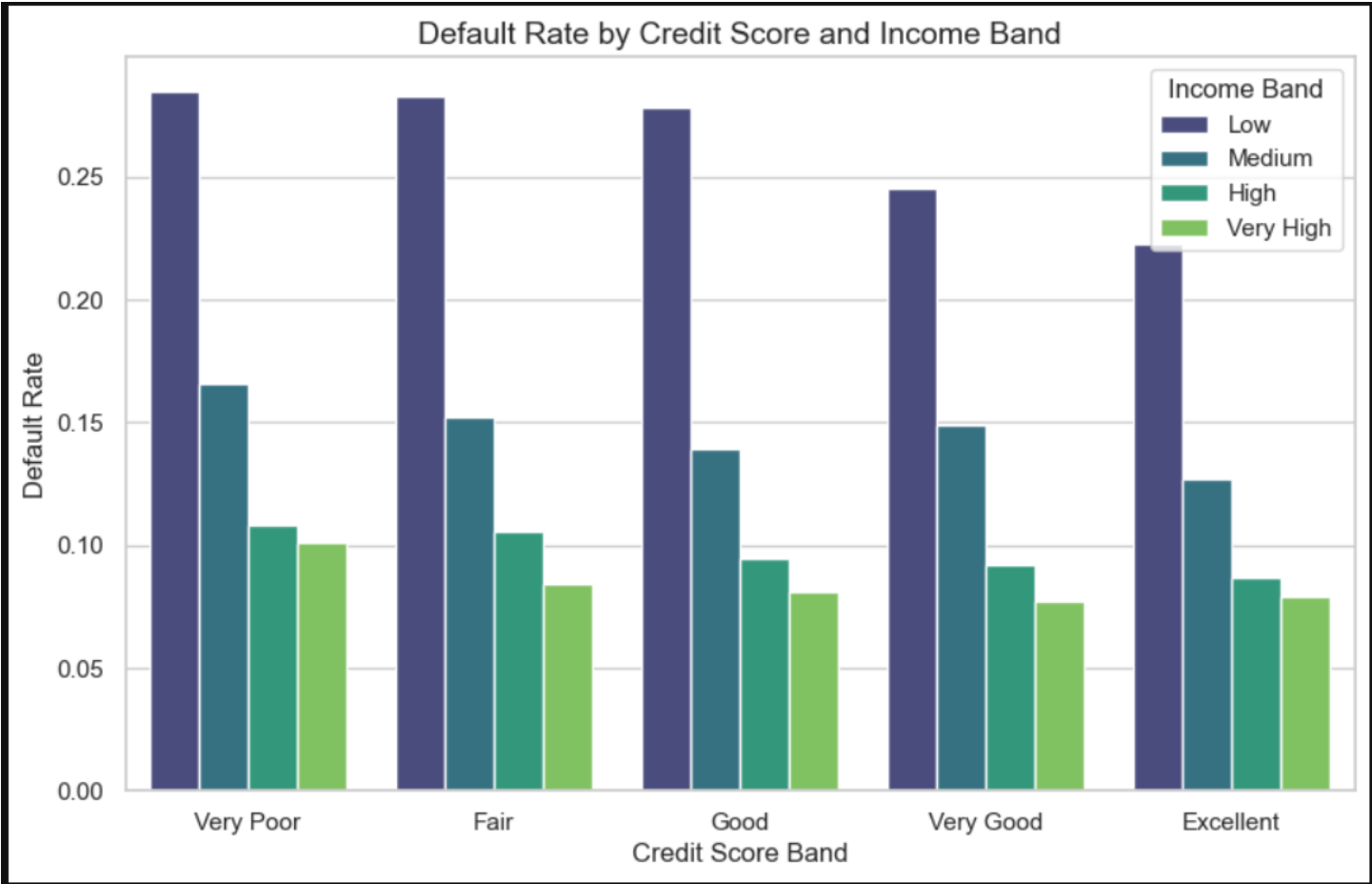
6.1 Hypotheses Summary Matrix

- Hypothesis 1: Borrowers in the "Low" Income Band (< \$20,000) with "Fair" or "Very Poor" Credit Scores exhibit the highest concentration of defaults. — Result: **Approved**
- Hypothesis 2: The absence of a co-signer increases the default rate across all borrower profiles. — Result: **Approved**
- Hypothesis 3: Unemployed borrowers represent a disproportionate risk, specifically when seeking Business or Education loans. — Result: **Approved**
- Hypothesis 4: High Debt-to-Income (DTI) ratios directly correlate with higher default rates. — Result: **Approved**

6.2 Detailed Hypothesis Breakdown

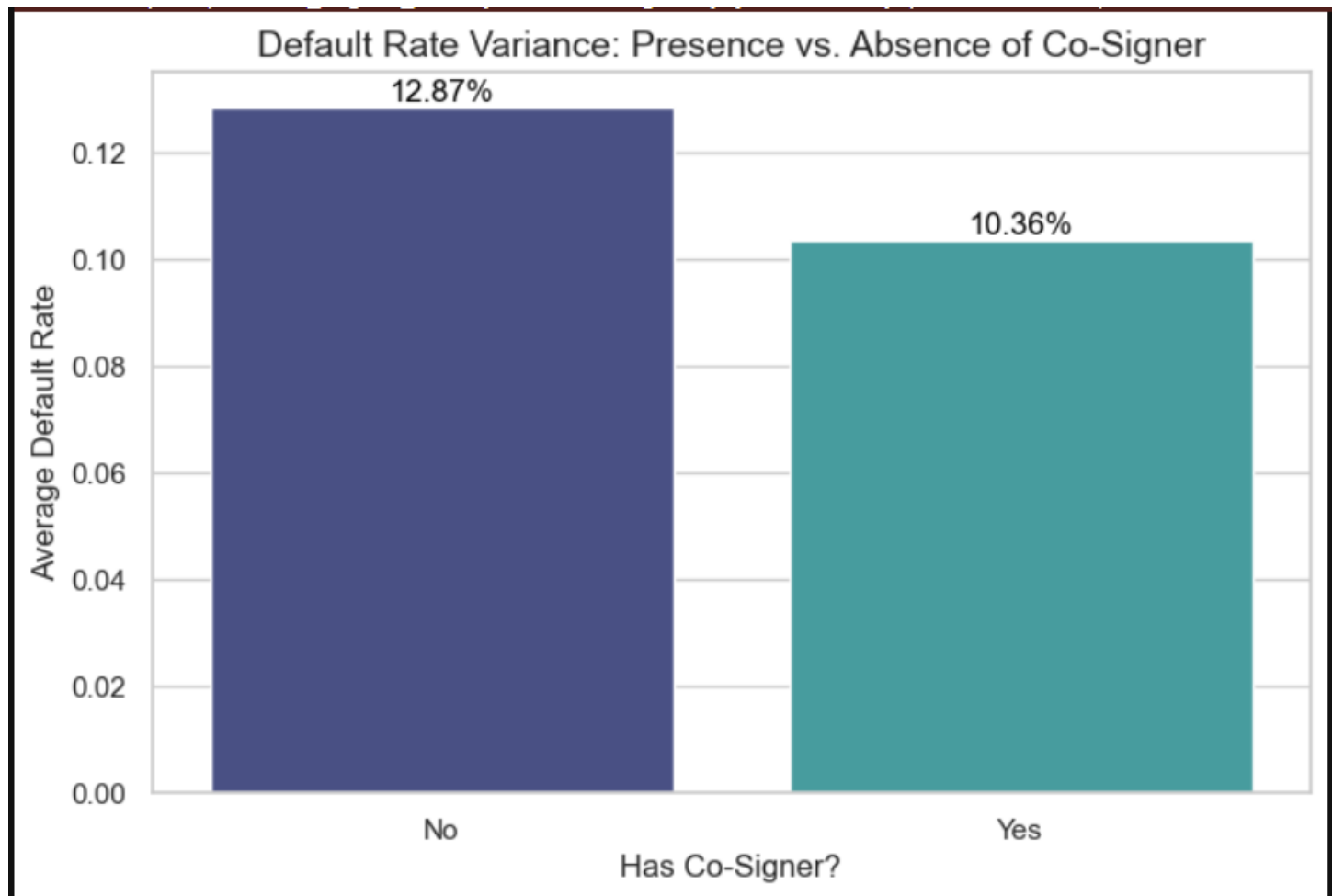
Hypothesis 1: Income Level vs. Credit Score

- **Hypothesis:** Borrowers in the "Low" Income Band (< \$20,000) with "Fair" or "Very Poor" Credit Scores exhibit the highest concentration of defaults.
- **Result:** **Approved.**
- **Methodology & Conclusion:** To test this assumption, a grouped bar chart was generated mapping the average default rate across standard Credit Score Bands, segmented by Income Band. The visual output confirmed the hypothesis but revealed a more severe underlying trend: absolute income level vastly outweighs historical credit scores. Borrowers in the "Low" income bracket consistently default at rates exceeding 20% across all credit score tiers. Strikingly, even borrowers with "Good," "Very Good," and "Excellent" credit scores remain highly likely to default if their income falls into this low band.



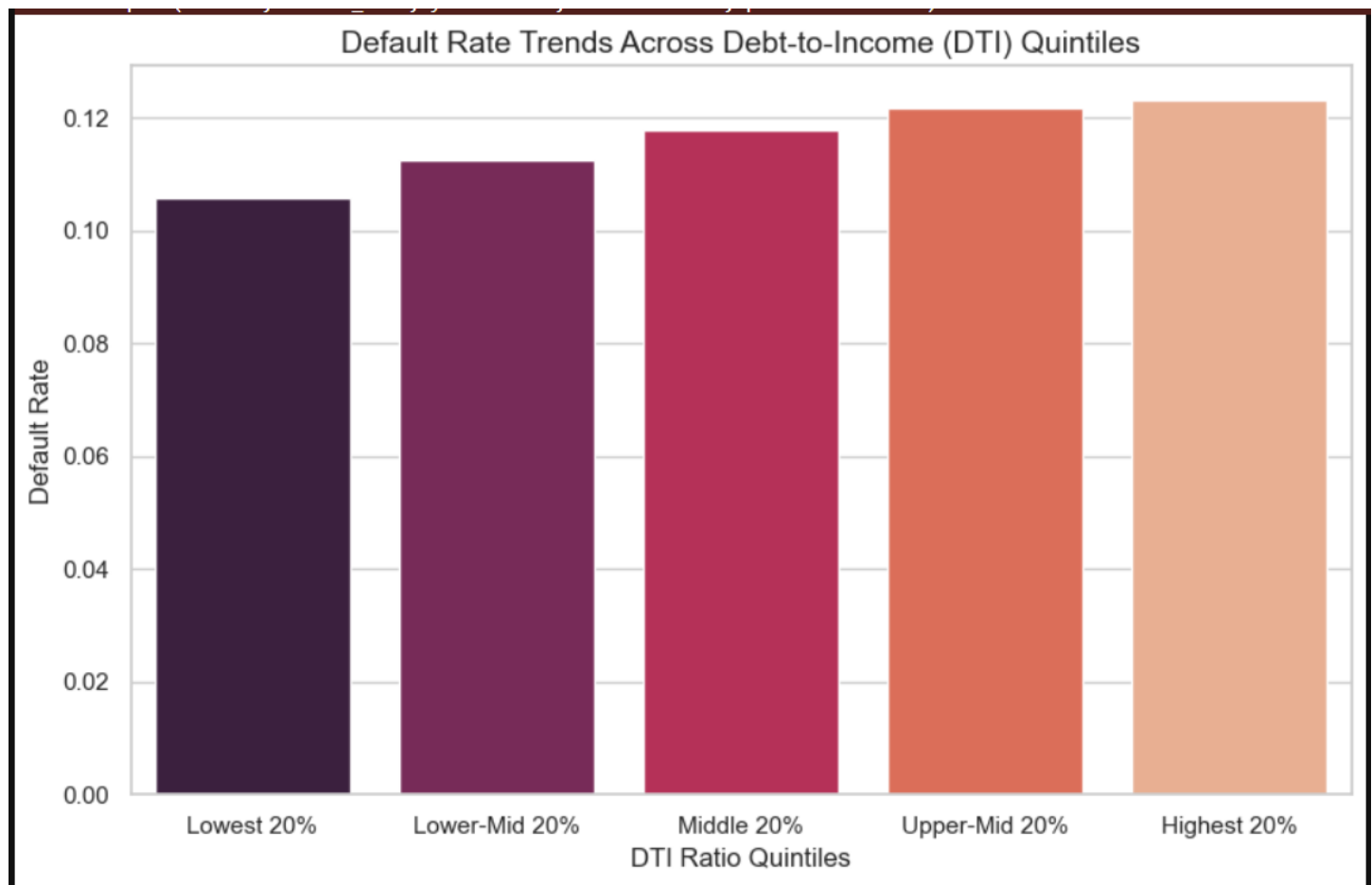
Hypothesis 2: The Co-Signer Risk Buffer

- **Hypothesis:** The absence of a co-signer increases the default rate across all borrower profiles.
- **Result:** Approved.
- **Methodology & Conclusion:** To isolate the impact of co-signers, average default rates were calculated and visualized in a bar chart comparing loans with and without a co-signer. The absence of a co-signer actively elevates the default risk profile, with unbacked borrowers defaulting at an average rate of 12.87%. In contrast, securing a co-signer significantly insulates the loan, dropping the default rate to 10.36%. This validates that a co-signer acts as a critical risk buffer.



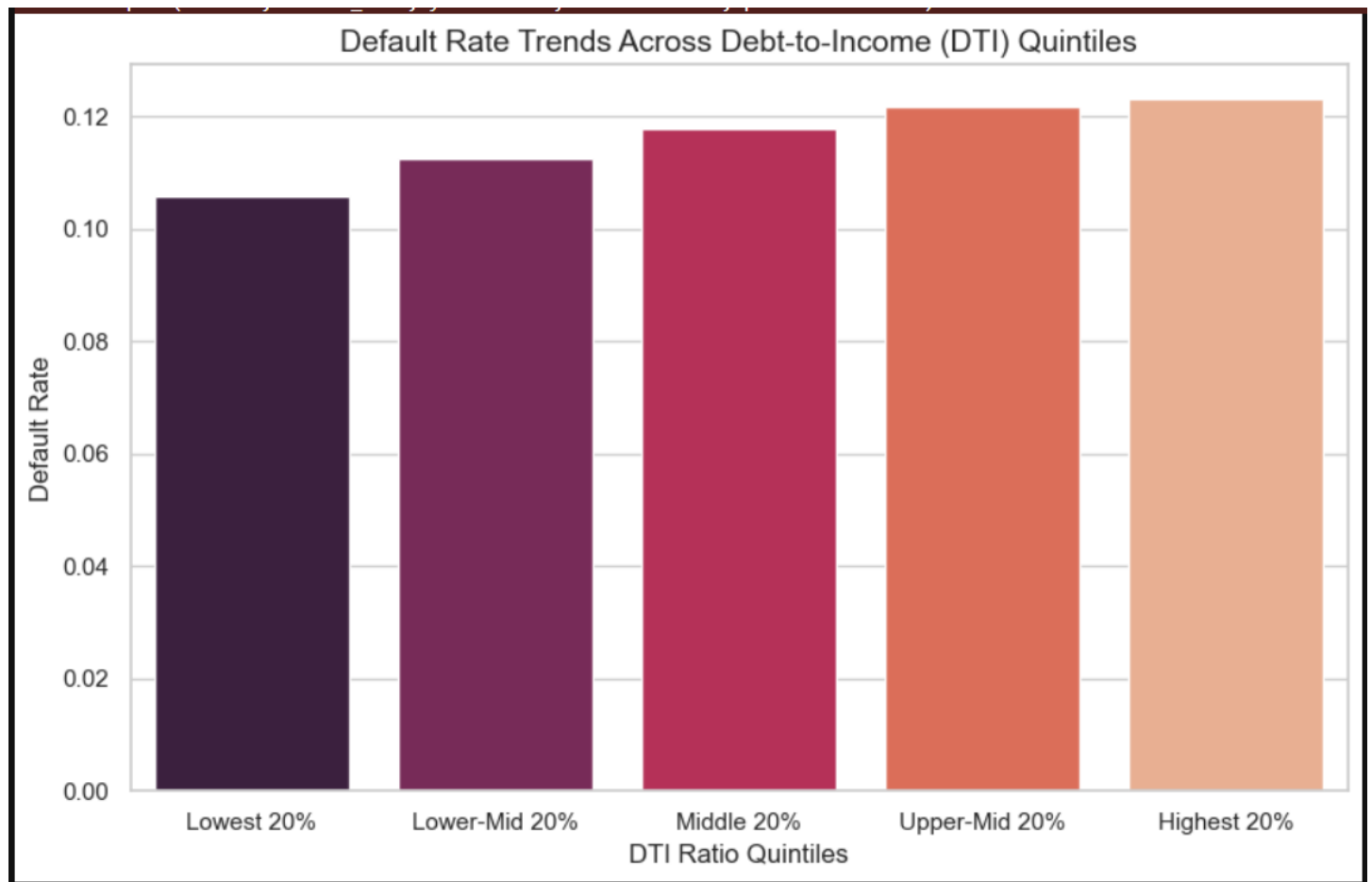
Hypothesis 3: Employment Stability & Loan Purpose

- **Hypothesis:** Unemployed borrowers represent a disproportionate risk, specifically when seeking Business or Education loans.
- **Result:** Approved.
- **Methodology & Conclusion:** Default rates were plotted across all five loan purposes and segmented by employment type using a clustered bar chart. The analysis proves that employment stability is critical to loan performance, as unemployed borrowers demonstrated the highest likelihood of default across every single loan category. Furthermore, part-time employees represent the second-highest risk group across these exact same categories. This confirms that unpredictable cash flow directly correlates with loan delinquency regardless of the capital's intended use.



Hypothesis 4: DTI Ratio Quintiles

- **Hypothesis:** High Debt-to-Income (DTI) ratios directly correlate with higher default rates.
- **Result:** Approved.
- **Methodology & Conclusion:** The continuous DTI Ratio feature was binned into five equal percentiles (Lowest 20% to Highest 20%) to test for linear risk escalation. The resulting bar chart displayed a clear, undeniable upward trend in defaults as the borrower's leverage increased. Borrowers in the lowest 20% DTI quintile default at roughly a 10.5% rate, which scales up linearly to over 12% for those in the highest 20% DTI quintile. This proves that highly leveraged borrowers are structurally more likely to default.

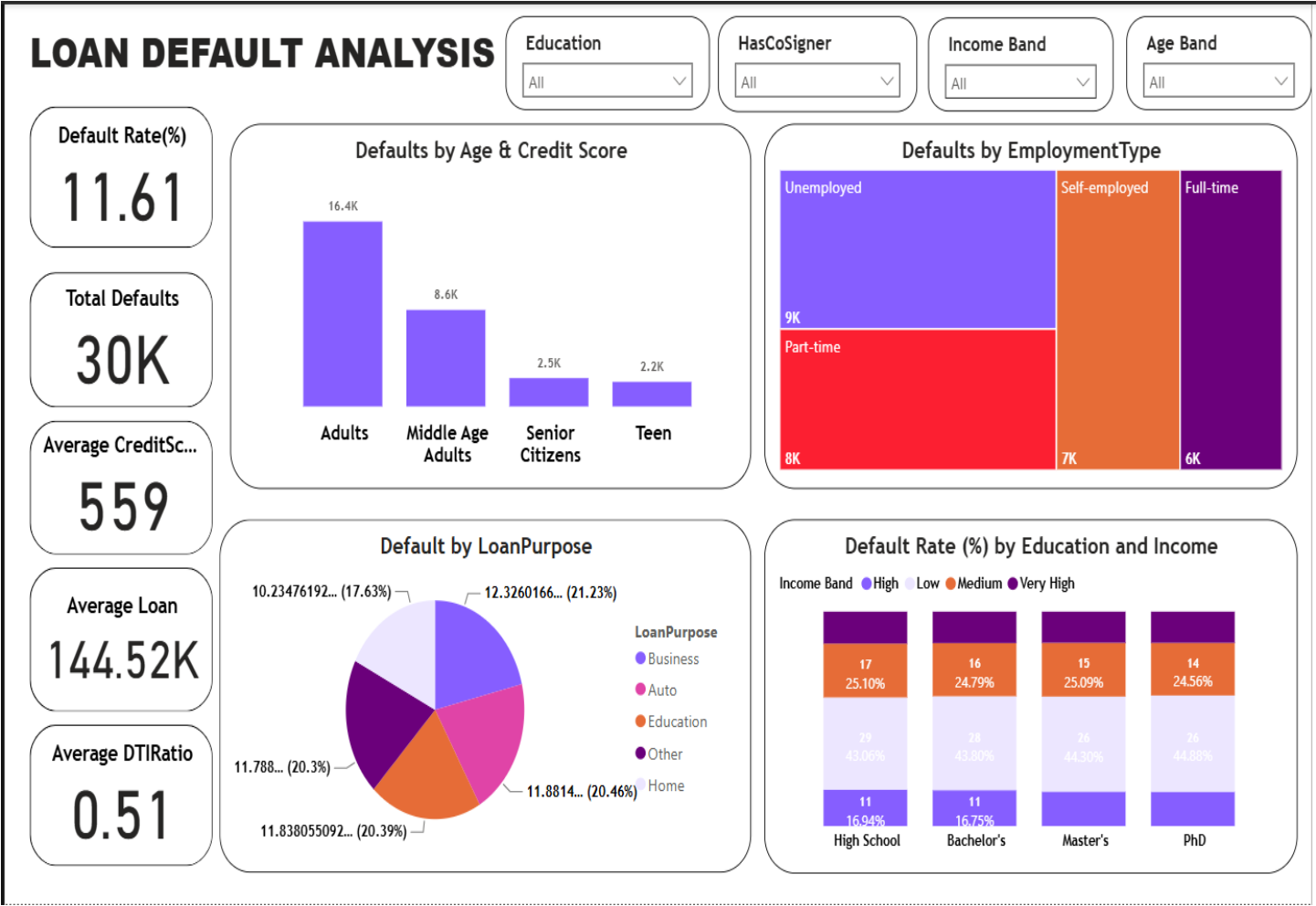


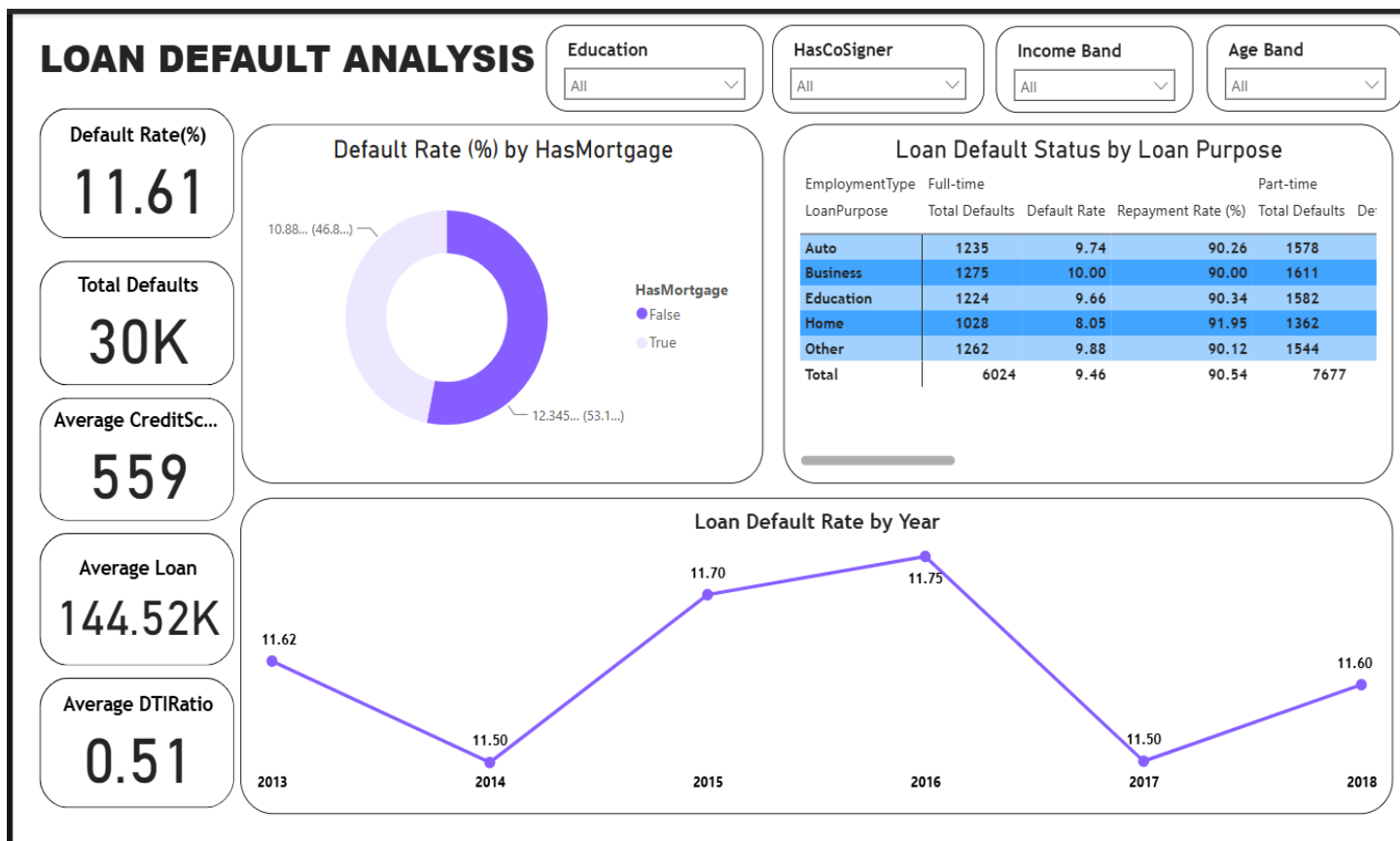
7. Financial Risk Dashboard

To operationalize the findings from the exploratory data analysis, an interactive Power BI tracking dashboard was developed. This tool allows risk and product managers to dynamically monitor portfolio health and isolate high-risk segments in real time.

The dashboard architecture was optimized for executive visibility, featuring a unified top ribbon that tracks critical KPIs, including the overall Default Rate (11.61%), Total Defaults (30K), Average Credit Score (559), Average Loan Amount (144.52K), and Average DTI Ratio (0.51). Global slicers for Education, HasCoSigner, Income Band and Age Band allow for synchronized filtering across the report.

The visual layout translates the EDA hypotheses into continuous monitoring tools, utilizing matrix heatmaps to track the intersection of Credit Score and Income Band, and clear bar charts to measure the isolated impacts of employment type and DTI quintiles.





8. Strategic Recommendations

The multidimensional risk profile constructed during the EDA phase highlights several areas where current lending policies can be optimized. To effectively mitigate risk while continuing to drive loan volume, the following cross-functional strategies are recommended:

Risk Management Strategies (Credit & Policy Optimization)

- Revise Income-to-Credit Matrices:** The data definitively proves that an "Excellent" credit score is an insufficient safeguard if the borrower falls into the "Low" income band. The institution must adjust automated underwriting algorithms to trigger mandatory manual reviews for any applicant earning less than \$20,000, regardless of their credit history.
- Implement Hard DTI Caps:** With a linear correlation observed between rising DTI ratios and escalating default rates, the institution should establish stricter lending limits for borrowers in the highest 20% DTI quintile. Borrowers crossing this specific leverage threshold should either be subject to immediate rejection or routed to a higher-yield interest rate tier to price the risk accordingly.
- Employment-Weighted Approvals:** Because unemployed and part-time applicants consistently drive the highest default volumes across Business and Education loans, these specific loan-to-employment combinations should be flagged as high-risk. Approval matrices for these segments should require elevated proof of liquidity or collateral.

Product Strategy (User Journey & Application Funnel)

- **Dynamic Co-Signer Integration:** The absence of a co-signer acts as a universal risk multiplier. The product team should integrate a dynamic, rules-based logic engine into the digital loan application funnel. If an applicant selects "Unemployed" or "Part-time," or their self-reported income falls into the "Low" band, the user interface should immediately adapt to require a co-signer to proceed with the application, effectively transferring the risk before underwriting begins.
 - **Adaptive Loan Sizing:** Rather than issuing flat rejections to applicants who present borderline DTI ratios or lack a co-signer, the application portal can be optimized to offer adaptive loan sizing. By automatically countering the applicant with a lower approved principal amount, the institution keeps the borrower's post-loan DTI within a safer, lower quintile while successfully retaining the customer.
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9. Conclusion

The historical reliance on isolated metrics, particularly raw credit scores, has created significant blind spots in the institution's risk evaluation framework. By pivoting toward a holistic, data-driven approach that prioritizes verifiable income bandwidth, employment stability, debt-to-income leverage, and co-signer backing, the institution can proactively identify toxic loans prior to issuance. Implementing these refined approval thresholds and dynamic product requirements will directly reduce the accumulation of non-performing assets, protect principal investments, and position the portfolio for sustainable, risk-adjusted profitability.
